MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 1: ELT - Approaches and Methods

ENGLISH LANGUAGE TEACHING • M21EG01AC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Good language teaching begins by understanding the learner’s language history, communicative needs, context, and developing knowledge.

Start with a picture

A person who needs to speak with patients and a person preparing to read literary criticism both need English, but not exactly the same course. Teaching starts with the question: what will this learner need to do, and what can they already do?

1. Acquisition and learning

The course distinguishes natural, less consciously monitored **acquisition** from more explicit **learning** of forms and rules. This is especially associated with Krashen’s framework. Real classrooms often combine meaningful exposure, interaction, explanation, practice, and reflection.

Do not turn the distinction into an absolute wall. A learner can notice a rule during conversation and use explicitly learned knowledge within meaningful activity. Claims about exactly how these processes relate need evidence.

2. L1 and L2

L1 usually names a first or early language; **L2** names an additional language in the discussion. A person may acquire several languages early, and their strongest language may change over time. These terms do not rank people’s intelligence or imply that everyone has one pure mother tongue.

Earlier languages can support learning through shared concepts, literacy, strategies, and comparison. **Transfer** can help or create difficulty; it is not always interference.

3. Bilingualism and multilingualism

Bilingual and multilingual people use different parts of their repertoires in different settings. Equal native-like command of every skill is not a requirement for recognising multilingual ability.

A multilingual classroom can use comparison, strategic translation, peer explanation, and accessible examples while also providing substantial English practice. A blanket ban on familiar languages may remove useful support.

4. ESL, EFL, and English varieties

ESL often refers to English used in a wider social or institutional environment; **EFL** often refers to learning where everyday use is less extensive. Actual contexts overlap, especially through migration and digital communication.

English in India has local histories and legitimate varieties. The teaching goal should be intelligible, effective, context-appropriate communication rather than imitation of one imagined native speaker in every situation.

5. Approach, method, and technique

An **approach** is a set of assumptions about language and learning. A **method** connects such assumptions with an organised teaching plan. A **technique** is a particular classroom action. More detailed models also distinguish design and procedure.

For example: a communicative approach can support a lesson in which pairs exchange missing information; the specific question cards and feedback procedure are techniques. Avoid treating the terms as synonyms.

6. Teacher-centred and learner-centred work

Teacher explanation can be efficient when brief and purposeful. Learner-centred work gives learners meaningful participation, choice, collaboration, and responsibility. The distinction concerns the organisation of learning, not whether a teacher ever speaks.

John Dewey’s emphasis on experience helps frame active learning. Activity alone, however, is not proof of a clear learning goal.

7. Interlanguage

A learner develops a partly systematic language that is neither simply their L1 nor the target norm. “She goed” can show an emerging rule for past tense, not random failure. Interlanguage changes through use, input, attention, and feedback. Persistent patterns are sometimes discussed as fossilisation, but teachers should not assume improvement is impossible.

8. ESP and needs analysis

English for Specific Purposes begins with needs: tasks, texts, audiences, constraints, and existing ability. Business English is one possible professional focus, not all of ESP.

For a nursing group, an objective might be clarifying a patient’s instructions. Teach useful forms, model the interaction, practise a realistic role play, and assess whether clarification actually succeeds.

Quick check

1. Must bilingual people use both languages equally well? **No.**
2. Is every error caused by L1 interference? **No.**
3. Is a lively activity enough to prove learning? **No; evidence must connect with the objective.**

Build an exam answer

1. Describe the learners and their communicative need.
2. Define the approach/method/technique distinction.
3. Choose an activity aligned with the objective.
4. Explain multilingual support and interlanguage-sensitive feedback.
5. Identify what observable performance would show progress.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not equate additional-language status with lower ability, forbid useful language resources automatically, or claim that a method label guarantees learning.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How should learner context inform the choice of an ELT approach and classroom activity?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

An ELT decision should begin with needs rather than loyalty to a method label. Learners differ in prior languages, literacy, opportunities to use English, and the tasks they must perform. ESL and EFL labels provide a broad description, but a specific course needs a closer account of audience, purpose, and existing ability.

A communicative objective, such as asking for clarification, must be translated into observable activity. The teacher can model a short exchange, draw attention to useful forms, and provide an information-gap task in which misunderstanding has to be resolved. Strategic use of familiar languages can support understanding without replacing the intended English practice. Learner-centredness is visible in meaningful participation, not simply in the absence of explanation.

Interlanguage provides a useful interpretation of the evidence produced. A recurring error may reveal an emerging rule rather than laziness. Feedback should identify the pattern and create a chance to use a better form in a new exchange. Success is assessed through both the completion of the communicative purpose and relevant language features.

The distinction among approach, method, and technique helps make the reasoning explicit. A theoretical assumption informs the design, while a technique implements one part of it. The final test is not whether the lesson looks fashionable, but whether it provides accessible practice and credible evidence of progress towards the learner’s goal.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. What are the prospects of learning a language like English? Illustrate with suitable examples.
2. Depending on the nature of the classroom-Bilingual or Multilingual, the teacher of English has to adopt an appropriate strategy. Explain
3. From your own experience, show how learning English is quite different from learning your mother tongue.
4. What is Approach and Method in the context of ELT?
5. Explain Teacher-centred and Learner-centred methods.
6. Differentiate between ‘acquisition’ and ‘learning’.
7. Explain Bilingualism and Multilingualism.
8. Elucidate ESL and EFL with examples.
9. Write a brief note on Interlanguage.
10. Explain ESP.